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AI



AI referrals to top
websites were up 357%
year-over-year in June,
reaching 1.13B

AI referrals to websites still have a way to go to catch up to the traffic that Google Search provides, but they're growing quickly. According to [new data](#) from market intelligence provider [Similarweb](#), AI platforms in June generated over 1.13 billion referrals to the top 1,000 websites globally, a figure that's up 357% since June 2024.

However, Google Search still accounts for the majority of traffic to these sites, accounting for 191 billion referrals during the same period of June 2025.

One particular category of interest these days is news and media. Online publishers are seeing traffic declines and are preparing for a day they're calling "Google Zero," when [Google stops sending traffic to websites](#).

For instance, The Wall Street Journal recently reported on data that showed how [AI overviews were killing traffic to news sites](#). Plus, a [Pew Research Center study](#) out this week found that in a survey of 900 U.S. Google users, 18% of some 69,000 searches showed AI Overviews, which led to users clicking links 8% of the time. When there was no AI summary, users clicked links nearly twice as much, or 15% of the time.

Similarweb found that June's AI referrals to news and media websites were up 770% since June 2024. Some sites will naturally rank higher than others

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that are blocking access to AI platforms, as The New York Times does, as a result of its lawsuit with OpenAI over the use of its articles to train its models.

In the news media category, Yahoo led with 2.3 million AI referrals in June 2025, followed by Yahoo Japan (1.9M), Reuters (1.8M), The Guardian (1.7M), India Times (1.2M), and Business Insider (1.0M).

In terms of methodology, Similarweb counts AI referrals as web referrals to a domain from an AI platform like ChatGPT, Gemini, DeepSeek, Grok, Perplexity, Claude, and Liner. ChatGPT dominates here, accounting for more than 80% of the AI referrals to the top 1,000 domains.

The company's analysis also looked at other categories beyond news, like e-commerce, science and education, tech/search/social media, arts and entertainment, business, and others.

- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
- The best dating apps aren't even dating apps

Top Recipients of AI Referrals Traffic by Category

AI Referrals by Category

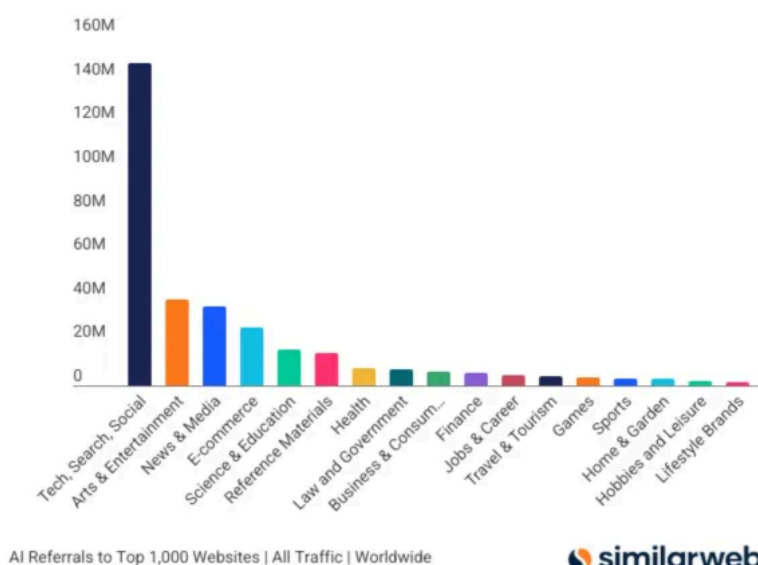


IMAGE CREDITS:SIMILARWEB

In e-commerce, Amazon was followed by Etsy and eBay when it came to those sites seeing the most

referrals, at 4.5M, 2.0M, and 1.8M, respectively, during June.

Among the top tech and social sites, Google, not surprisingly, was at the top of the list, with 53.1 million referrals in June, followed by Reddit (11.1M), Facebook (11.0M), Github (7.4M), Microsoft (5.1M), Canva (5.0M), Instagram (4.7M), LinkedIn (4.4M), Bing (3.1M), and Pinterest (2.5M).

The analysis excluded the OpenAI website because so many of its referrals were from ChatGPT, pointing to its services.

Across all other domains, the No. 1 site by AI referrals for each category included YouTube (31.2M), Research Gate (3.6M), Zillow (776.2K), Europa.eu (992.9K), Wikipedia (10.8M), NIH.gov (5.2M), Investing.com (1.2M), Home Depot (1.2M), Kayak (456.5K), and Zara (325.6K).

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Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [🦋](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Google denies AI search features are killing website traffic

Sarah Perez — 12:45 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

Numerous studies indicate that the [shift to AI search features](#) and the use of [AI chatbots](#) are killing traffic to publishers' sites. But Google on Wednesday denied that's the case, at least in aggregate. Instead, the search giant says that total organic click volume from its search engine to websites has been "relatively stable" year-over-year and that average click quality has slightly increased.

"This data is in contrast to third-party reports that inaccurately suggest dramatic declines in aggregate traffic — often based on flawed methodologies, isolated examples, or traffic changes that occurred prior to the roll out of AI features in Search," writes Google VP and Head of Search, Liz Reid, in [a new blog post](#).

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Though Google hasn't shared any specific data to back up its conclusions, even if we assume Google's claims to be true, this doesn't necessarily mean that AI isn't having an impact.

Even Google has to admit this, as Reid acknowledges that “user trends are shifting traffic to different sites, resulting in decreased traffic to some sites and increased traffic to others.”

That word “some” is doing heavy lifting here, as Google doesn't share data about how many sites are gaining or losing. And while chatbots like ChatGPT have certainly seen traffic increase in recent months, that doesn't mean online publishers aren't suffering.



IMAGE CREDITS:GOOGLE

Google has been revamping its search engine for years to answer more questions directly on the search results page, and now does so with AI through its “AI Overviews” that appear at the top of search results. Google also allows users to interact with an AI chatbot for some queries. Yet Google denies that this is significantly reshaping the search landscape. Rather, it points to users shifting their attention to other sites to start their queries.

Reid explains, “People are increasingly seeking out and clicking on sites with forums, videos, podcasts, and posts where they can hear authentic voices and first-hand perspectives.”

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Reading between the lines, it seems like Google.com isn't necessarily people's first stop on the web these days. But that's something we've known for some time. Back in 2022, a Google exec even said that social sites like TikTok and Instagram [were eating into Google's core products](#), like Search and Maps.

"In our studies, something like almost 40% of young people, when they're looking for a place for lunch, they don't go to Google Maps or Search," said Google SVP Prabhakar Raghavan, who ran the company's Knowledge and Information organization at the time (he is now its chief technologist). "They go to TikTok or Instagram," he noted.

Google has also long been worried that Amazon.com had become people's first stop for online shopping searches, and Reddit.com had become the first stop for researching topics of interest.

Over many years, the company has tried to come up with compelling features for both consumers and retailers that would attract more users to Google Shopping. These efforts have included [universal shopping carts](#), [local inventory checks](#), [deal finders](#), [shopping from product images on websites](#), and more. It even [made its Shopping listings free](#) for merchants in 2020.

Meanwhile, as users [complained that Google Search quality was declining](#), the search giant was

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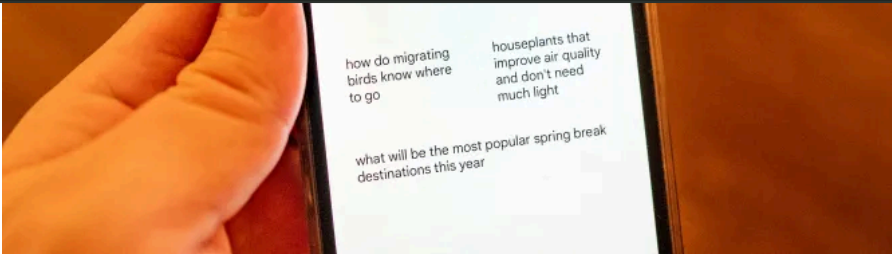


IMAGE CREDITS: SMITH COLLECTION/GADO / GETTY IMAGES

Google's new blog post also attempts to move the goalposts a bit about what it means for websites receiving Google's clicks. Now, instead of counting clicks, it wants publishers to think about click quality.

The company says average click quality has increased, and Google is sending "slightly more quality clicks" to websites than a year ago. (Google explains that a quality click is one where users don't quickly click back — they stay and read.) How much of an increase, though, Google doesn't say. The company only points out that when people click through on an AI response to the source, they're more likely to dive deeper, so those clicks are more valuable.

What's more, Google paints AI as an opportunity for web publishers to gain increased exposure, saying that "with AI Overviews, people are seeing more links on the page than before," Reid writes. "More queries and more links mean more opportunities for websites to surface and get clicked."

But AI, [while a growing referral source](#), isn't [yet making up the difference](#) in terms of clicks, reports have shown. One recent study from Similarweb indicates that the number of news searches on the web resulting in zero clicks to news websites has

grown from 56% (when Google launched AI Overviews in May 2024) to 69% as of May 2025.



IMAGE CREDITS:SIMILARWEB

Google appears to know this is a trend, too, as it recently launched [a product for publishers](#) that helps them monetize their dwindling traffic in other ways that don't rely only on advertising, like micropayments or newsletter sign-ups.

The fact that Google is pushing this “AI is not the end of search traffic!” PR now only makes the situation seem more dire. It's as if Google wants publishers to believe not what their own eyes — and graphs and charts — tell them, but instead take comfort in the fact that Google still sends “billions of clicks to websites” every day, just as the post claims.

Topics: [AI](#) [Google](#) [media](#) [Media & Entertainment](#)
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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor |

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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Google's AI Mode can now have back-and-forth voice conversations

Aisha Malik — 9:00 AM PDT · June 18, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS:

Google is rolling out the ability for users to have a back-and-forth voice conversation with AI Mode, its experimental Search [feature](#) that lets users ask complex, multi-part questions. With the new [Search Live](#) integration, users can have a free-flowing voice conversation with Search and explore links from across the web.

Users will be able to access the feature by opening the Google app and tapping the new “Live” icon to ask their question aloud. They will then hear an AI-generated audio response, and they can follow up with another question.

Today’s announcement comes a few weeks after [Google rolled out AI Mode](#) to everyone in the U.S. The launch of the feature was seen as Google’s answer to popular services like Perplexity AI and OpenAI’s ChatGPT Search. With this new update, Google is looking to take on those services’ respective voice modes.

Google says the feature will be useful in instances where you’re on the go or multitasking. For example, if you’re packing for a trip, you can ask a question like “What are some tips for preventing a linen dress from wrinkling in a suitcase?” You could follow up with another question like “What should I do if it still wrinkles?”



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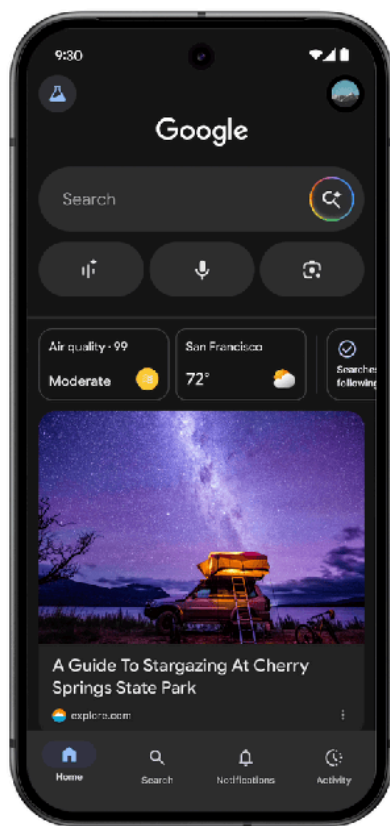
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Google takes on ChatGPT’s Study Mode with new ‘Guided Learning’ tool in Gemini

Aisha Malik - 14 hours ago



Results for illustrative purposes and may vary. Check for accuracy.

IMAGE CREDITS:GOOGLE

As you’re having the conversation, you’ll find links right on your screen if you want to dig deeper into your search.

Because Search Live works in the background, you can continue the conversation while in another app. Plus, you have the option to tap the “transcript” button to view the text response and continue to ask questions by typing if you’d like to. You can also revisit a Search Live response by navigating to your AI Mode history.

“Behind the scenes, Search Live in AI Mode uses a custom version of Gemini with advanced voice capabilities,” Liza Ma, the director of product management at Google Search, explained in a [blog post](#). “Our custom model is built on Search’s best-in-class quality and information systems, so you still get reliable, helpful responses no matter where or how you’re asking your question. Search Live with voice also uses our query fan-out technique to show you a wider and more diverse set of helpful



web content, enabling new opportunities for exploration.”

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In the coming months, Google plans to bring more Live capabilities to AI Mode, including letting you ask questions based on what your phone’s camera is seeing in real time, as [was previewed at Google I/O](#) in May.

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Aisha Malik

Consumer News Reporter | X

Aisha is a consumer news reporter at TechCrunch. Prior to joining the publication in 2021, she was a telecom reporte...

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